

VirtualPathProvider Class (System.Web.Hosting)

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Content

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VirtualPathProvider Class

Definition

Namespace: [System.Web.Hosting](#) Assembly: System.Web.dll

Important

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Provides a set of methods that enable a Web application to retrieve resources from a virtual file system.

```
public ref class VirtualPathProvider abstract : MarshalByRefObject
```

```
public abstract class VirtualPathProvider : MarshalByRefObject
```

```
type VirtualPathProvider = class
    inherit MarshalByRefObject
```

```
Public MustInherit Class VirtualPathProvider
    Inherits MarshalByRefObject
```

Inheritance

[Object](#)

[MarshalByRefObject](#)

[VirtualPathProvider](#)

Examples

The following code example is a [VirtualPathProvider](#) class implementation that creates a virtual file system using information stored in a [DataSet](#) object. The code example works with the code examples for the [VirtualFile](#) and [VirtualDirectory](#) classes to provide virtual resources from a data store that is loaded into a [DataSet](#) object.

This example has four parts: the [VirtualPathProvider](#) class implementation, an XML data file used to populate the [DataSet](#) object, an `AppStart` object that contains an `AppInitialize` method used to register the [VirtualPathProvider](#) class with the compilation system, and an ASP.NET page that provides links to the virtual files.

To use this sample code in an application, follow these steps.

-

Create a sample application on your Web server.

-

Copy the source code for the custom [VirtualPathProvider](#) object (see below) into a file in the application's `App_Code` directory.

-

Copy the source code for the custom [VirtualDirectory](#) object (see the Example section in the [VirtualDirectory](#) class overview topic) into a file in the application's `App_Code` directory.

-

Copy the source code for the custom [VirtualFile](#) object (see the Example section in the [VirtualFile](#) class overview topic) into a file in the application's `App_Code` directory.

-

Copy the source code for the `AppStart` object (see below) into a file in the application's `App_Code` directory.

-

Copy the XML data (see below) into a file named `XMLData.xml` into a file in the application's `App_Data` directory.

-

Copy the `default.aspx` file (see below) into the root directory of the sample application. Use a Web browser to open the `default.aspx` file, and then click the links on the page to see the contents of the virtual files.

The first example is a custom [VirtualPathProvider](#) class. The [DirectoryExists](#) and [FileExists](#) methods are overridden to indicate whether a requested directory is present in the virtual file system. The [GetDirectory](#) and [GetFile](#) methods are overridden to return custom [VirtualDirectory](#) and [VirtualFile](#) instances containing information from the virtual file system.

The class also provides a `GetVirtualData` method used by the [VirtualDirectory](#) and [VirtualFile](#) classes to access the [DataSet](#) object containing the virtual file system data. In a production implementation, this method would typically be implemented in a business object responsible for interacting with the data store.

```

using System;
using System.Data;
using System.Security.Permissions;
using System.Web;
using System.Web.Caching;
using System.Web.Hosting;

namespace Samples.AspNet.CS
{
    [AspNetHostingPermission(SecurityAction.Demand, Level =
AspNetHostingPermissionLevel.Medium)]
    [AspNetHostingPermission(SecurityAction.InheritanceDemand, Level =
AspNetHostingPermissionLevel.High)]
    public class SamplePathProvider : VirtualPathProvider
    {
        private string dataFile;

        public SamplePathProvider()
            : base()
        {
        }

        protected override void Initialize()
        {
            // Set the datafile path relative to the application's path.
            dataFile = HostingEnvironment.ApplicationPhysicalPath + "App_Data\\XMLData.xml";
        }

        /// <summary>
        /// Data set provider for the SampleVirtualDirectory and
        /// SampleVirtualFile classes. In a production application
        /// this method would be on a provider class that accesses
        /// the virtual resource data source.
        /// </summary>
        /// <returns>
        /// The System.Data.DataSet containing the virtual resources
        /// provided by the SamplePathProvider.
        /// </returns>
        public DataSet GetVirtualData()
        {
            // Get the data from the cache.
            DataSet ds = (DataSet)HostingEnvironment.Cache.Get("VPPData");
            if (ds == null)
            {

```

```

        // Data not in cache. Read XML file.
        ds = new DataSet();
        ds.ReadXml(dataFile);

        // Make DataSet dependent on XML file.
        CacheDependency cd = new CacheDependency(dataFile);

        // Put DataSet into cache for maximum of 20 minutes.
        HostingEnvironment.Cache.Add("VPPData", ds, cd,
            Cache.NoAbsoluteExpiration,
            new TimeSpan(0, 20, 0),
            CacheItemPriority.Default, null);

        // Set data timestamp.
        DateTime dataTimeStamp = DateTime.Now;
        // Cache it so we can get the timestamp in later calls.
        HostingEnvironment.Cache.Insert("dataTimeStamp", dataTimeStamp, null,
            Cache.NoAbsoluteExpiration,
            new TimeSpan(0, 20, 0),
            CacheItemPriority.Default, null);
    }
    return ds;
}

/// <summary>
///     Determines whether a specified virtual path is within
///     the virtual file system.
/// </summary>
/// <param name="virtualPath">An absolute virtual path.</param>
/// <returns>
///     true if the virtual path is within the
///     virtual file system; otherwise, false.
/// </returns>
private bool IsPathVirtual(string virtualPath)
{
    String checkPath = VirtualPathUtility.ToAppRelative(virtualPath);
    return checkPath.StartsWith("~/vrdir",
StringComparison.InvariantCultureIgnoreCase);
}

public override bool FileExists(string virtualPath)
{
    if (IsPathVirtual(virtualPath))
    {

```

```

        SampleVirtualFile file = (SampleVirtualFile)GetFile(virtualPath);
        return file.Exists;
    }
    else
    {
        return Previous.FileExists(virtualPath);
    }
}

public override bool DirectoryExists(string virtualDir)
{
    if (IsPathVirtual(virtualDir))
    {
        SampleVirtualDirectory dir = (SampleVirtualDirectory)GetDirectory(virtualDir);
        return dir.Exists;
    }
    else
    {
        return Previous.DirectoryExists(virtualDir);
    }
}

public override VirtualFile GetFile(string virtualPath)
{
    if (IsPathVirtual(virtualPath))
    {
        return new SampleVirtualFile(virtualPath, this);
    }
    else
    {
        return Previous.GetFile(virtualPath);
    }
}

public override VirtualDirectory GetDirectory(string virtualDir)
{
    if (IsPathVirtual(virtualDir))
    {
        return new SampleVirtualDirectory(virtualDir, this);
    }
    else
    {
        return Previous.GetDirectory(virtualDir);
    }
}

public override CacheDependency GetCacheDependency(
    string virtualPath,
    System.Collections.IEnumerable virtualPathDependencies,
    DateTime utcStart)
{
    if (IsPathVirtual(virtualPath))

```

```

{
    System.Collections.Specialized.StringCollection fullPathDependencies = null;

    // Get the full path to all dependencies.
    foreach (string virtualDependency in virtualPathDependencies)
    {
        if (fullPathDependencies == null)
            fullPathDependencies = new System.Collections.Specialized.StringCollection();

        fullPathDependencies.Add(virtualDependency);
    }
    if (fullPathDependencies == null)
        return null;

    // Copy the list of full-path dependencies into an array.
    string[] fullPathDependenciesArray = new string[fullPathDependencies.Count];
    fullPathDependencies.CopyTo(fullPathDependenciesArray, 0);
    // Copy the virtual path into an array.
    string[] virtualPathArray = new string[1];
    virtualPathArray[0] = virtualPath;

    return new CacheDependency(virtualPathArray, fullPathDependenciesArray,
utcStart);
    }
    else
    {
        {
            return Previous.GetCacheDependency(virtualPath, virtualPathDependencies,
utcStart);
        }
    }
}
}

```

```
Imports System.Data
Imports System.Security.Permissions
Imports System.Web
Imports System.Web.Caching
Imports System.Web.Hosting
```

```
Namespace Samples.AspNet.VB
```

```
    <AspNetHostingPermission(SecurityAction.Demand,
Level:=AspNetHostingPermissionLevel.Medium), _
    AspNetHostingPermission(SecurityAction.InheritanceDemand,
level:=AspNetHostingPermissionLevel.High)> _
```

```
    Public Class SamplePathProvider
        Inherits VirtualPathProvider
```

```
        Private dataFile As String
```

```
        Public Sub New()
            MyBase.New()
        End Sub
```

```
        Protected Overrides Sub Initialize()
            ' Set the datafile path relative to the application's path.
            dataFile = HostingEnvironment.ApplicationPhysicalPath & _
                "App_Data\XMLData.xml"
        End Sub
```

```
        ' Data set provider for the SampleVirtualFile and
        ' SampleVirtualDirectory classes. In a production application
        ' this method would be on a provider class that accesses
        ' the virtual resource data source.
        ' The System.Data.DataSet containing the virtual resources
        ' provided by the SamplePathProvider.
```

```
        Public Function GetVirtualData() As DataSet
            ' Get the data from the cache.
            Dim ds As DataSet
            ds = CType(HostingEnvironment.Cache.Get("VPPData"), DataSet)
```

```
        If ds Is Nothing Then
            ' Data set not in cache. Read XML file.
            ds = New DataSet
            ds.ReadXml(dataFile)

            ' Make DataSet dependent on XML file.
```

```

Dim cd As CacheDependency
cd = New CacheDependency(dataFile)

' Put DataSet into cache for maximum of 20 minutes.
HostingEnvironment.Cache.Add("VPPData", ds, cd, _
    Cache.NoAbsoluteExpiration, _
    New TimeSpan(0, 20, 0), _
    CacheItemPriority.Default, Nothing)

' Set data timestamp.
Dim dataTimeStamp As DateTime
dataTimeStamp = DateTime.Now
' Cache it so we can get the timestamp in later calls.
HostingEnvironment.Cache.Add("dataTimeStamp", dataTimeStamp, Nothing, _
    Cache.NoAbsoluteExpiration, _
    New TimeSpan(0, 20, 0), _
    CacheItemPriority.Default, Nothing)
End If
Return ds
End Function

Private Function IsPathVirtual(ByVal virtualPath As String) As Boolean
    Dim checkPath As String
    checkPath = VirtualPathUtility.ToAppRelative(virtualPath)
    Return checkPath.StartsWith("~/vrdir", StringComparison.InvariantCultureIgnoreCase)
End Function

Public Overrides Function FileExists(ByVal virtualPath As String) As Boolean
    If (IsPathVirtual(virtualPath)) Then
        Dim file As SampleVirtualFile
        file = CType(GetFile(virtualPath), SampleVirtualFile)
        Return file.Exists
    Else
        Return Previous.FileExists(virtualPath)
    End If
End Function

Public Overrides Function DirectoryExists(ByVal virtualDir As String) As Boolean
    If (IsPathVirtual(virtualDir)) Then
        Dim dir As SampleVirtualDirectory
        dir = CType(GetDirectory(virtualDir), SampleVirtualDirectory)
        Return dir.exists
    Else
        Return Previous.DirectoryExists(virtualDir)
    End If
End Function

```

```
End If
End Function
```

```
Public Overrides Function GetFile(ByVal virtualPath As String) As VirtualFile
    If (IsPathVirtual(virtualPath)) Then
        Return New SampleVirtualFile(virtualPath, Me)
    Else
        Return Previous.GetFile(virtualPath)
    End If
End Function
```

```
Public Overrides Function GetDirectory(ByVal virtualDir As String) As
VirtualDirectory
    If (IsPathVirtual(virtualDir)) Then
        Return New SampleVirtualDirectory(virtualDir, Me)
    Else
        Return Previous.GetDirectory(virtualDir)
    End If
End Function
```

```
Public Overrides Function GetCacheDependency(ByVal virtualPath As String, ByVal
virtualPathDependencies As IEnumerable, ByVal utcStart As Date) As CacheDependency
    If (IsPathVirtual(virtualPath)) Then

        Dim fullPathDependencies As System.Collections.Specialized.StringCollection
        fullPathDependencies = Nothing

        ' Get the full path to all dependencies.
        For Each virtualDependency As String In virtualPathDependencies
            If fullPathDependencies Is Nothing Then
                fullPathDependencies = New System.Collections.Specialized.StringCollection
            End If

            fullPathDependencies.Add(virtualDependency)
        Next

        If fullPathDependencies Is Nothing Then
            Return Nothing
        End If

        Dim fullPathDependenciesArray As String()
        fullPathDependencies.CopyTo(fullPathDependenciesArray, 0)

        Return New CacheDependency(fullPathDependenciesArray, utcStart)
```

```
Else
    Return Previous.GetCacheDependency(virtualPath, virtualPathDependencies,
utcStart)
End If
End Function
End Class
End Namespace
```

The second example is the XML data file used to populate the [DataSet](#) object returned by the custom [VirtualPathProvider](#) object. This XML data is used to demonstrate using the [VirtualPathProvider](#), [VirtualDirectory](#), and [VirtualFile](#) objects to retrieve data from external data and is not intended to represent a production-quality data store.

```
<?xml version="1.0" encoding="utf-8" ?>
<resource type="dir"
  path="/vrDir"
  parentPath=""
  content="">
  <resource type="file"
    path="/vrDir/Level1FileA.vrf"
    parentPath="/vrDir"
    content="This is the content of file Level1FileA.">
  </resource>
  <resource type="file"
    path="/vrDir/Level1FileB.vrf"
    parentPath="/vrDir"
    content="This is the content of file Level1FileB.">
  </resource>
  <resource type="dir"
    path="/vrDir/Level2DirA"
    parentPath="/vrDir"
    content="">
    <resource type="file"
      path="/vrDir/Level2DirA/Level2FileA.vrf"
      parentPath="/vrDir/Level2DirA"
      content="This is the content of file Level2FileA.">
    </resource>
    <resource type="file"
      path="/vrDir/Level2DirA/Level2FileB.vrf"
      parentPath="/vrDir/Level2DirA"
      content="This is the content of file Level2FileB.">
    </resource>
  </resource>
  <resource type="dir"
    path="/vrDir/Level2DirB"
    parentPath="/vrDir"
    content="">
    <resource type="file"
      path="/vrDir/Level2DirB/Level2FileA.vrf"
      parentPath="/vrDir/Level2DirB"
      content="This is the content of file Level2FileA.">
    </resource>
    <resource type="file"
      path="/vrDir/Level2DirB/Level2FileB.vrf"
      parentPath="/vrDir/Level2DirB"
      content="This is the content of file Level2FileB.">
    </resource>
  </resource>
</resource>
```

```
</resource>
</resource>
```

The third example provides an `AppStart` object that contains an `AppInitialize` method. This method is called during the initialization of an ASP.NET application to perform any custom initialization required. In this case, it registers the custom [VirtualPathProvider](#) object with the ASP.NET build system.

```
using System.Web.Hosting;

namespace Samples.AspNet.CS
{
    /// <summary>
    ///     Contains the application initialization method
    ///     for the sample application.
    /// </summary>
    public static class AppStart
    {
        public static void AppInitialize()
        {
            SamplePathProvider sampleProvider = new SamplePathProvider();
            HostingEnvironment.RegisterVirtualPathProvider(sampleProvider);
        }
    }
}
```

```
Imports System.Web.Hosting

Namespace Samples.AspNet.VB

    Public Class AppStart

        Public Shared Sub AppInitialize()
            Dim sampleProvider As SamplePathProvider = New SamplePathProvider()
            HostingEnvironment.RegisterVirtualPathProvider(sampleProvider)
        End Sub

    End Class

End Namespace
```

The last example is an ASP.NET page that contains links to the virtual files contained in the virtual file system.

```
<%@ Page Language="C#" %>

<!DOCTYPE html PUBLIC "-//W3C//DTD XHTML 1.0 Transitional//EN"
"http://www.w3.org/TR/xhtml1/DTD/xhtml1-transitional.dtd">

<script runat="server">

</script>

<html xmlns="http://www.w3.org/1999/xhtml">
<head runat="server">
  <meta http-equiv="Content-Type" content="text/html" />
  <title>Virtual Path Provider Example</title>
</head>
<body>
  <form id="form1" runat="server">
    <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink1" runat="server" NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level1FileA.vrf"
Text="Level 1, File A" /><br />
    <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink2" runat="server" NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level1FileB.vrf"
Text="Level 1, File B" /><br />
    <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink3" runat="server"
NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level2DirA/Level2FileA.vrf" Text="Level 2a, File A" /><br />
    <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink4" runat="server"
NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level2DirA/Level2FileB.vrf" Text="Level 2a, File B" /><br />
    <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink5" runat="server"
NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level2DirB/Level2FileA.vrf" Text="Level 2b, File A" /><br />
    <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink6" runat="server"
NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level2DirB/Level2FileB.vrf" Text="Level 2b, File B" /><br />
  </form>
</body>
</html>
```

```

<%@ Page Language="VB" %>

<!DOCTYPE html PUBLIC "-//W3C//DTD XHTML 1.0 Transitional//EN"
"http://www.w3.org/TR/xhtml1/DTD/xhtml1-transitional.dtd">

<html xmlns="http://www.w3.org/1999/xhtml" >
<head runat="server">
    <meta http-equiv="Content-Type" content="text/html" />
    <title>Virtual Path Provider Example</title>
</head>
<body>
    <form id="form1" runat="server">
        <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink1" runat="server" NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level1FileA.vrf"
Text="Level 1, File A" /><br />
        <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink2" runat="server" NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level1FileB.vrf"
Text="Level 1, File B" /><br />
        <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink3" runat="server"
NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level2DirA/Level2FileA.vrf" Text="Level 2a, File A" /><br />
        <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink4" runat="server"
NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level2DirA/Level2FileB.vrf" Text="Level 2a, File B" /><br />
        <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink5" runat="server"
NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level2DirB/Level2FileA.vrf" Text="Level 2b, File A" /><br />
        <asp:HyperLink ID="hyperLink6" runat="server"
NavigateUrl="vrDir/Level2DirB/Level2FileB.vrf" Text="Level 2b, File B" /><br />
    </form>
</body>
</html>

```

Remarks

The [VirtualPathProvider](#) class provides a set of methods for implementing a virtual file system for a Web application. In a virtual file system, the files and directories are managed by a data store other than the file system provided by the server's operating system. For example, you can use a virtual file system to store content in a SQL Server database.

You can store any file that is processed on request in a virtual file system. This includes:

-

ASP.NET pages, master pages, user controls, and other objects.

-

Standard Web pages with extensions such as .htm and .jpg.

-

Any custom extension mapped to a [BuildProvider](#) instance.

-

Any named theme in the `App_Theme` folder.

You cannot store ASP.NET application folders or files that generate application-level assemblies in a virtual file system. This includes:

-

The `Global.asax` file.

-

`Web.config` files.

-

Site map data files used by the [XmlSiteMapProvider](#).

-

Directories that contain application assemblies or that generate application assemblies:

`Bin` , `App_Code` , `App_GlobalResources` , any `App_LocalResources` .

-

The application data folder, `App_Data` .

Note

If a Web site is precompiled for deployment, content provided by a [VirtualPathProvider](#) instance is not compiled, and no [VirtualPathProvider](#) instances are used by the precompiled site.

Registering a VirtualPathProvider

A custom [VirtualPathProvider](#) instance should be registered with the ASP.NET compilation system by using the [HostingEnvironment.RegisterVirtualPathProvider](#) method before any page parsing or compilation is performed by the Web application.

Typically, a [VirtualPathProvider](#) instance is registered in an `AppInitialize` method defined in the `App_Code` directory, or during the `Application_Start` event in the `Global.asax` file. For an example of registering a [VirtualPathProvider](#) instance in an `AppInitialize` method, see the Example section.

You can register a [VirtualPathProvider](#) instance during other events, but pages compiled and cached before the [VirtualPathProvider](#) instance is registered will not be invalidated, even if the new [VirtualPathProvider](#) instance would now provide the source for the previously compiled page.

Notes to Implementers

When you inherit from [VirtualPathProvider](#), you must override the following members:

-

[FileExists\(String\)](#)

-

[GetFile\(String\)\)](#)

If your custom [VirtualPathProvider](#) class supports directories in the virtual file system, you must override the following members.

-

[DirectoryExists\(String\)\)](#)

-

[GetDirectory\(String\)\)](#)

Note: If your virtual file system will contain themes for the Web site (by creating a virtual `App_Themes` directory), your custom [VirtualPathProvider](#) class must support directories.

A custom [VirtualPathProvider](#) class works with classes derived from the [VirtualFile](#) and [VirtualDirectory](#) classes. You should implement derived classes from these types to provide file and directory information from your virtual file system. For an example of a custom [VirtualFile](#) implementation, see the Example section of the [VirtualFile](#) class overview topic. For an example of a custom [VirtualDirectory](#) implementation, see the Example section of the [VirtualDirectory](#) class overview topic.

Constructors

Name	Description
VirtualPathProvider()	

Initializes the class for use by an inherited class instance. This constructor can be called only by an inherited class.

||

Properties

Name	Description
Previous	

Gets a reference to a previously registered [VirtualPathProvider](#) object in the compilation system.

||

Methods

Name	Description
CombineVirtualPaths(String, String))	

Combines a base path with a relative path to return a complete path to a virtual resource.

CreateObjRef(Type))	
-------------------------------------	--

Creates an object that contains all the relevant information required to generate a proxy used to communicate with a remote object.

(Inherited from [MarshalByRefObject](#)) | | | [DirectoryExists\(String\)](#) |

Gets a value that indicates whether a directory exists in the virtual file system.

| | | [Equals\(Object\)](#) |

Determines whether the specified object is equal to the current object.

(Inherited from [Object](#)) | | | [FileExists\(String\)](#) |

Gets a value that indicates whether a file exists in the virtual file system.

| | | [GetCacheDependency\(String, IEnumerable, DateTime\)](#) |

Creates a cache dependency based on the specified virtual paths.

| | | [GetCacheKey\(String\)](#) |

Returns a cache key to use for the specified virtual path.

| | | [GetDirectory\(String\)](#) |

Gets a virtual directory from the virtual file system.

| | | [GetFile\(String\)](#) |

Gets a virtual file from the virtual file system.

| | | [GetFileHash\(String, IEnumerable\)](#) |

Returns a hash of the specified virtual paths.

| | | [GetHashCode\(\)](#) |

Serves as the default hash function.

(Inherited from [Object](#)) | | | [GetLifetimeService\(\)](#) |

Obsolete.

Retrieves the current lifetime service object that controls the lifetime policy for this instance.

(Inherited from [MarshalByRefObject](#)) | | | [GetType\(\)](#) |

Gets the [Type](#) of the current instance.

(Inherited from [Object](#)) | | | [Initialize\(\)](#) |

Initializes the [VirtualPathProvider](#) instance.

| | | [InitializeLifetimeService\(\)](#) |

Gives the [VirtualPathProvider](#) object an infinite lifetime by preventing a lease from being created.

| | | [MemberwiseClone\(\)](#) |

Creates a shallow copy of the current [Object](#).

(Inherited from [Object](#)) | | | [MemberwiseClone\(Boolean\)](#) |

Creates a shallow copy of the current [MarshalByRefObject](#) object.

(Inherited from [MarshalByRefObject](#)) | | | [OpenFile\(String\)](#) |

Returns a stream from a virtual file.

||| [ToString\(\)](#) |

Returns a string that represents the current object.

(Inherited from [Object](#)) ||

Applies to

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